

Mexico. A few years after that, oil prices fell. The one-two punch of tighter money and falling oil prices pounded the Mexican peso from 25 to the dollar to over 2,000. But you'll never find those peso bargains if you stay at the high-rise hotels in Ixtapa or Puerto Vallarta, because those places peg prices to the dollar. Their customers are worn-out executives, battered lawyers, and unappreciated civil servants who want a week on the beach without complications. But if you venture a couple of miles away from the tourist areas, you'll find cool fruit drinks for a dime, complete meals for a dollar, hotels without nonworking air-conditioners for \$5 to \$10 a night, and taxis that will take you on a half-day tour for \$20.

Like most visitors to Mexico, Vicki and I land in international airports in Cancún, Zihuantanejo/Ixtapa, or Puerto Vallarta. But once on the ground we head for small fishing villages or larger cities rather than the concrete and glass tourist strips. We prefer the municipal beach in Zihuantanejo, for example, to the manicured sand of nearby Ixtapa. On the beach in Zihuantanejo a boy comes around every so often and asks for a nickel. That's a fee for using the beach. He'll also run to get you a beer for a quarter or a taco for a dime. In Ixtapa, a few miles up the Pacific, the Mexican tourist board has built a massive resort. A taco on the beach in Ixtapa comes with a plate of things you don't want and costs \$5. The waiter who brings it to you accepts the American Express card.

Whether they stay in shiny, dollar-based resorts or in the unpackaged countryside, about half of Mexico's visitors wind up with intestinal problems. Called "Montezuma's revenge" or simply the *turistas*, the painful stomach pains and diarrhea can ruin short vacations. Avoid drinking the water, they say, and you avoid the *turistas*. But I never drink the water, and I nearly always get the *turistas*. The problem goes away after a few days and seldom comes back. One dose seems to immunize you for the rest of the trip. For those who stay in Mexico for a month or two, there's a fifty/fifty chance of avoiding the